

科幻短篇：回溯机器

≡ 标签

人生方向

≡ 简述

她应该努力让自己在某些方面胜过过的自己，并非事事都比以前完美

≡ 声明

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≡ 备注

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On the 3rd of October 2351 a machine flared to life. Huge energies coursed into it via cables, only to leave moments later as heat dumped unwanted into its radiators. With an enormous puff the machine unleashed sixty years of human metabolic entropy into superheated steam.

2351年10月3日，一台机器苏醒了。巨大的能量通过电缆注入其中，又在瞬间以废热形式倾泻至散热装置。伴随着一声闷响，这台机器将人类六十年积累的代谢熵，尽数释放为灼热蒸汽。

In the heart of the machine was Jane, a person of the early 21st century.

机器的核心，安静地躺着一个来自21世纪初的人类——简（Jane）。

From her perspective there was no transition. One moment she had been in the year 2021, sat beneath a tree in a park. Reading a detective novel.

对她而言，这一切没有任何过渡。上一刻，她还坐在2021年的公园里，在树荫下翻着一本侦探小说。

Then the book was gone, and the tree. Also the park. Even the year.

下一刻，书没了，树不见了，公园消失了——甚至连时间本身也不复存在了。

She found herself laid in a bathtub, immersed in sickly fatty fluids. She was naked and cold.

她发现自己赤裸地躺在某种浴缸中，浸泡在粘稠的脂质液体里，寒意渗透全身。

The first question Jane had for the operators and technicians who greeted her with a warm towel was "where am I?". They brought back the dead a hundred times a day, and knew that it was best to answer when, not where.

操作员和技术人员为她递上温热的毛巾，她提出的第一个问题是：“我这是在哪？”。操作员每天要“复活”上百人，他们深知此刻应回答的是“你现在在什么时候”。

Jane's second question was "how did I come to be in the year 2351?".

简的第二个问题紧随其后：“我怎么会来到2351年？”

The answer begins in the year 2021. Jane sat beneath a tree. She read her book. She walked home. She attended university. She played her guitar. Went to pubs and festivals with her

friends. She studied philosophy as her course, but there wasn't much work going in analysing Plato so she got a job in marketing.

答案，要从2021年说起。那时，简坐在树下看书，散步回家，上大学，弹吉他，和朋友们泡吧、赶音乐节。她主修哲学，但柏拉图并不能带来好工作，于是她转行去做了市场营销。

She married, had children. Lived a normal enough life.

后来，她结了婚，生了孩子，过上平凡的人生。

She followed the scientific news no more than most. She did watch the much-hyped documentary about the possibility of restoring objects to a previous state. She found it a disappointment. So they could get a single molecule to unreact? Maybe some chemist somewhere cared.

她对科技新闻并不算特别关注。她曾看过一部宣传很猛的纪录片，讲的是将物体“回溯”到旧状态的技术。她看完觉

得不过尔尔——不过是让分子逆反应而已，这种事大概也就化学家会兴奋吧。

But technology's march was unceasing. The egg was unboiled only two decades later.

可技术从未停下脚步。二十年后，那颗熟鸡蛋真的被“回生”了。

The redaction machines, as they came to be known, restored an object to a previous state. Set the machine for 10 minutes and insert your alarm clock. Ping! The machine takes no time at all to operate. Within find alarm clock, time as it read 10 minutes ago.

这种装置被称作“回溯机”。它能让物体恢复到某一时刻的状态。比如你把闹钟放进去，设定为10分钟前，叮！它立刻完成操作，取出来的闹钟就显示着10分钟前的时间。

Smash said alarm clock with hammer. Insert the pieces into the machine. Activate. Find alarm clock restored, exactly, to state 10 minutes prior. No longer smashed. It is not now a repaired alarm clock. If something has been repaired then one supposes that it was once broken. A repaired thing still possesses the history of being broken and then fixed. But that clock, as taken from the machine, is the clock from earlier, before it ever suffered damage. Its history taken from it. The breakage unhappened.

哪怕你用锤子砸碎了它，把碎片塞进机器，再启动——闹钟也会被完整还原，不是“修好”，而是彻底“回到未曾碎裂”的状态。修复意味着它曾坏过，但这个被回溯的闹钟，根本不曾坏过，它的破碎被彻底抹去，仿佛从未发生。

The first resurrection was only a half-decade after the egg. By the same token as the clock this was not truly a resurrection. It was a restoration, an undoing of time's passage on a single person. "Resurrection", despite its flaws as a term, became the standard manner of speaking about these things.

五年后，第一个人类被“回溯”。这其实也不是“复活”，只是对某个人的时间倒流。但“复活”这个词听起来够酷，于是成了大家默认的叫法。

Accidental death dropped to almost zero in the developed world. Or at least, unredacted, accidental death did. Truly the number of deaths increased modestly, as some people became more brazen. But nearly all were redacted.

在发达国家，意外死亡几乎绝迹——或者说，数据上是这样。实际上，因为人们胆子更大了，死亡率反而略有回升，但所有的死亡几乎都被“回溯”了。

Ambulances would carry the corpses made by a traffic accident to a redaction clinic. Death 1 hour ago. Re-set patient. It would be a shock to transition from driving to a strange hospital, with no memory of the accident (the neurochemistry encoding any such memory was just as unhappened as the tearing of ligaments and the crush of bones). But it was surely better than being dead.

救护车把交通事故造成的尸体送去回溯诊所。设定：死亡一小时前，启动——人被重置。从驾驶状态直接跳到陌生病房，但对事故毫无记忆（因为记录那一刻的神经化学反应、断裂的韧带和骨折，都被一起回退了）。虽说有点吓人，但至少比真的死掉强。

During redaction every subatomic particle in an object would run its past trajectory backwards as best it could. The theory of relativity demanded that centre-of-mass motion of the object as a whole be an exception to this rule. Reality complied.

回溯时，物体中每一个亚原子粒子都沿原路径逆行。根据相对论，整个物体的质心运动除外，而现实也确实遵守了这一限制。

For humans, respiration acted in reverse. Blood cells passed backwards through arteries, carrying newly minted oxygen from the muscles out to the lungs to exhale. Electrical impulses travelled the nervous system in the wrong direction.

Was there sensation? Was there pain? In forwards time these electrical signals could stimulate these qualia. When played backwards in an eyeblink? Who could say. Even if there was pain there was no memory of it, no possibility of memory.

人体的呼吸系统会开始反转：血液从肌肉中携带“新鲜氧气”回流至肺部并呼出。神经电信号朝反方向传导。会有感觉吗？会痛吗？在顺时中这些电信号能激发感觉，那在一闪而过的逆时中呢？谁也说不清。就算有痛觉，也不会留下记忆，更别提创伤。

The panelled walls of the redaction machine broadcast energy and radiation inwards to drive this back-propagation.

Reflected back from the object came heat and entropy, radiated by these same panels outwards into coolant systems that comprised the bulk of the machine's volume and complexity.

回溯机的镶板墙体向内发射能量与辐射，驱动着粒子的逆转。而被回溯物体释放的热与熵，则被这些墙体吸收并引

导至庞大的冷却系统——这部分构成了机器最复杂、最重要的核心结构。

There were many theological objections. The greatest complaints came from the Abrahamic faiths. Although the Catholic church took no official stance on the machine many of its priests denounced it. The mechanics of the objections were varied. Some claimed that people restored to life (or even to a previous state) were soulless automatons: zombies that made an act of life after the one true soul of the person had departed for the afterlife. An alternative claim was that the machine pulled the soul back into the mortal plane. However most did not ground their objection in any particular metaphysical explanation, instead opting to convey honestly uninformed disquiet.

神学界对此技术提出了诸多异议，反对声浪最激烈的来自亚伯拉罕诸教。天主教会虽未正式表态，但许多神职人员公开谴责这项技术。反对理由五花八门：有人声称，被“复原”的人只是没有灵魂的仿生傀儡——他们模仿活人动作，但“真正的灵魂”早已升入天国；也有人主张，这台机

器强行把灵魂从彼岸拽回尘世。然而，更多反对者并未执着于某种形而上的理论解释，只是坦率地表达一种说不清的、源自本能的不安。

Despite these spiritual disputes, use of the machine propagated fast. Undoing death in accidents was the tip of the iceberg. Next came other accidental injury, loss of limb for example.

尽管精神伦理争议不断，机器的普及速度依旧势如破竹。“逆转死亡”不过是冰山一角，接下来各种意外伤害也成了可逆过程——断肢、烧伤、甚至误食洗洁精（再次强调，不要这么干）。

Jane herself was redacted for the first time in 2063. Her age was 64. Her cause of death: slipping on icy porch stairs. She hit her head on the corner of a square stone flower pot.

简第一次经历回溯是在2063年，那年她64岁。死因是一个经典悲剧：冬天，她在结冰的门廊上滑倒，头撞在方形石盆的棱角上。

She was still alive when they redacted her. The doctors hadn't even tried to treat her head wound. They took one look and knew that their conventional ministrations had very little chance of preserving her life, and that even if she did survive she would never be the same. It was better to just zap the last hours off her.

她被回溯时其实还活着。医生没做任何抢救，只是看了一眼伤势，就判断常规治疗毫无希望——即便救活了，也可能终身残疾。于是，他们干脆抹去了她最后几个小时的存在轨迹，让时间“倒退”至未出事之前。

She, of course, had no memory of sustaining the injury.

她自然不记得发生过什么。

After this encounter with these new machines Jane took an interest in them. She spoke at dinner parties about whether she was the same "her" who she had been before being reset.

She followed the various legal issues in the news with intense curiosity.

这次经历让简对“回溯机”产生了极大兴趣。她在社交聚会上津津乐道：“现在的我，还是那时候的我吗？”她热衷于跟进新闻里关于机器合法性与伦理性的讨论，仿佛在追一部剧情极慢的悬疑剧。

The murder trial fascinated her. Could he be convicted? He had killed a woman in cold blood, the evidence was indisputable. But, he had later redacted himself. This him had no memory of committing murder, nor even (he claimed) of planning it.

其中一桩谋杀案尤其令她着迷。嫌犯冷血杀人，证据确凿。但他在案发后对自己进行了回溯——这版本的“他”没有任何作案记忆，甚至声称根本没有预谋。

He was, in the end, found guilty. Sentenced to three years imprisonment. This was a typical enough sentence for murder

in the modern world. After all, the murder-victim was completely fine.

最终他还是被判有罪，获刑三年。在这个时代，谋杀量刑普遍偏轻，毕竟受害者如今毫发无损。

The machines became tools of both scientific and criminal enquiry. Information security was changed, as the concept of "deleted data" became a dinosaur. A wiped hard drive could be redacted. Even a physically vandalised hard drive could be similarly restored.

这项技术成了科学研究与刑事侦查的新工具。在信息安全领域，它彻底改变了规则：“删除数据”这个概念变得过时。被格式化的硬盘可以复原，哪怕是被物理破坏的硬盘，也能重建如初。

The dinosaurs themselves could not be recovered. Redaction conserved mass, so to make a healthy Tyrannosaur from its fossils one needed to place enough surplus matter in the machine to make up the difference. Mass enough to knit flesh

and blood around the skeleton. However, reliable machine operation required that the great majority of the mass within the machine was from the target object. This was why a person was restored to a previous state and not their breakfast toast. More mass was interested in reverting to a previously human state. Dinosaurs could not be done. Enough ballast to flesh them out was also too much for the fossils to win out the mass-contest. They did manage to bring back a frozen mammoth though, and the machine found various other uses in the field of palaeontology.

但恐龙，依然无法复活。回溯机制遵循质量守恒原则——若想以一具恐龙化石重生血肉，必须额外添加大量有机物作为“填充”。而机器要求被回溯物体在质量中占绝对多数，这意味着化石在机器中没有“投票权”。所以，尽管科学家尝试过很多次，恐龙还是没能复活。不过他们倒是成功复原了一只冷冻猛犸象。在古生物学领域，这项技术开启了新纪元。

Other sciences found uses for the machines. In physics laboratories redaction machines were used to reset atoms to

their state at around the time of the Big Bang. Chemists, engineers, all made good use of the technology.

其他科学领域也纷纷借力这项黑科技。物理学家用它将原子重置回“宇宙大爆炸”时的状态，化学家和工程师则用它玩出了更多奇葩花样。

However, to Jane's fascination, the field of science to gain the most was psychology.

但令简惊讶的是，心理学竟成为最大受益者。

Before the machines, psychology studies typically involved a control group and a test group. The two groups naturally exposed to situations that differed only according to a single experimental parameter. Any difference in the average response between the two groups, over and above statistical fluctuation, could be attributed to the control parameter. Each person was different, each responded differently. You needed enough people so that fluctuations at the individual level were sufficiently erased, leaving only population tendencies.

在回溯技术诞生之前，心理学研究主要依赖传统的实验设计：设置实验组与对照组，将两组人置于情境几乎完全一致、仅有一个变量差异的环境中。研究者通过对比两组的平均反应，判断该变量是否对行为或心理状态造成显著影响。只要差异超出统计波动的合理范围，就可以将其归因于该控制变量。

With the machines a single, identical, person could be exposed to both situations. They could take the survey given to them by a woman. Then you could reset them, on an atomic level, to the exact state they had been in beforehand. If you changed nothing they would give the same response, how could they not? But this time see how they responded to the same survey given by a man.

而有了回溯机，同一个人可以被反复放入不同情境，每次都从完全相同的起始状态开始。你可以先让某人接受一个由女性主持的问卷调查，记录答案。然后将他完全重置，再让一位男性主持同样的问卷。

A change in response need not be a group effect. Not some average tendency in a given population. It would be a replicable trait attributable exactly to that one person, in that exact state they were in at the start of the experiment. Does the room temperature affect the way this specific person responds to losing a rigged game? Well, let's get that exact person to play that game in the same room twenty times at twenty different temperatures, each time resetting them back to the same start-state.

反应的差异，不再只是群体性的平均趋势，而是某个具体个体，在特定状态下的可重复心理特征。它不需要大样本、不依赖人口统计学模型，而是精准归因于“这个人，在实验开始时的那个状态”。比如：房间的温度会影响某个具体人对作弊游戏失败的情绪反应吗？那就让这个人，在同一个房间里，进行二十次游戏，每次都将其重置回同一个起点状态，唯一变化就是室温。实验数据由此呈现的，是那个人本身，而非一类人群。

Of course some prospective participants refused to have such machines used on them. But many people were happy to

participate in these experiments, especially when offered financial incentives.

当然，有些人拒绝参与这种实验——谁愿意拿自己当原子级复读机？但也有不少人乐于尝试，尤其是在报酬丰厚的情况下。

Despite the many ingenious applications to which the machines were put, people still grew old. Accident was quite a different beast from disease and old age. When a young person was killed in a kinetic moment resetting was an obvious course of action. But when the elderly died slowly from chronic conditions the machines were less obviously applicable. Reset granny to before she developed the tumour? How many years ago was that again?

尽管机器已被广泛应用于各类复杂场景，但人类依然会衰老。意外事故与慢性病的性质截然不同：一个年轻人在车祸中丧命，回溯操作自然毫不犹豫；但当一位老人因肿瘤缓慢病亡，要回溯她到“未患病”状态，得追溯到多少年前？

Many things fed into the new tradition. The demographic crisis played a part. Redaction machine company lobbying perhaps contributed. However it happened, it soon became ingrained.

各种社会因素共同催生了“重置传统”。人口老龄化带来的危机、回溯技术公司的游说推动，还有对“高龄失能”的恐惧——不管原因如何，这一新做法迅速被大众接受。

Many things fed into the new tradition. The demographic crisis played a part. Redaction machine company lobbying perhaps contributed. However it happened, it soon became ingrained.

一些人在遗嘱中写明了“回溯年龄”：“我去世后，请将我回溯至21岁，以当前技术可达的最精确数据为准。”

It wasn't so much that you survived, but that some kind of version of you survived. Was the "you" of sixty years ago

"you"? Most people decided dubious reincarnation was better than cremation.

这不是“原本的你”幸存下来，而是某个“曾经的你”被复原了出来。六十年前的你，真的是现在的你吗？多数人最终得出的结论是——相比骨灰盒，这种模糊的重生已经够不错了。

The early twenties was a typical reset age. There were several reasons for this. First came practicality. You needed to emerge from the machine old enough to take care of yourself. If you were still a dependent then who would you depend on? Your parents were probably long gone.

二十岁出头成为最常见的回溯目标年龄。原因很简单：首先是实用性。你从机器中苏醒，必须具备独立生活能力。太小意味着你仍需监护人，而你的父母很可能早已不在人世。

The next reason was government poking. Old person, retired: expensive. Redact them back and you have a new worker for

the economy. Redact them too far and they become expensive again, they are a child, they need looking after. Redact them to middle age and they are difficult, they had a job and a family, they want those things back. Nevermind the industry is gone and the family are now either dead or hopelessly out of sync in time. No, the early twenties were best. Back when they had done their schooling but had yet to really latch on like a limpet to some part of the economic organism. So redacting to your twenties was subsidised, and subsidised heavily.

其次，是政策引导。老年人退休后成为财政负担，而重置他们、让他们重新投身劳动力市场，意味着新的经济产出。但若回溯太远变成孩子，又需要他人照料，得不偿失；若重置到中年阶段，他们往往试图追回旧日生活，而旧日已不复存在——家庭破碎，行业消失，时间错位。相比之下，二十出头的青年刚完成基础教育，还未真正绑定社会角色，最易重新上路。因此，各国政府都对“青年回溯”提供了慷慨补贴。

Finally came nostalgia. People liked the person they had been back at that sort of age.

最后一个原因，则是怀旧——人们怀念那个时候的自己，那个理想主义还未被现实打磨的版本。

Jane was one of the early adopters of the "new iteration" approach to death. Setting it all up was damned expensive: she died at ninety - about 70 years of redaction time multiplied by a typical human metabolic rate and mass landed you with a lot of redaction entropy. Look at the price of energy, convert the Kilowatt hours and it came to a lot of money. She had to set up an on-death remortgage of her home to cover it even with the subsidies.

简是最早采用“重启式死亡”方案的人之一。但要操作这么一次，可不是“关机再开机”那么简单。她在九十岁去世，要将她回溯到21岁，等于是抹除整整七十年的人生轨迹。考虑到人类单位质量下的代谢速率，这会制造巨量的回溯熵。算上当时的能源价格，这不是“昂贵”，这是“天文数

字”。即便享有补贴，她仍需要将自己的房产设立“身后抵押贷款”来支付这笔费用。

A young Jane emerged from a redaction machine. A young woman in a strange world. She found an unfamiliar house, mortgaged to pay for an unfamiliar treatment. She lived a new life, married, retrained as a pharmacist. She had occasional, awkward, meetings with the children from her last iteration. These children were far older than she was and she had no memory of raising them. Once they took her to the grave of their father, the husband she didn't remember. She left flowers at the stranger's tombstone, puzzled and bored by the experience. She spent most of it thinking about how foolish it seemed in hindsight to have scattered his ashes so widely.

一位年轻的简从机器中醒来。她是一个陌生的年轻女子，置身于一个完全陌生的世界。她找到了那套被抵押给未来科技的房子，重新展开生活、重新择业，成为药剂师。偶尔，她会与前一轮人生中所生的孩子碰面。那些人比她年长许多，而她完全不记得曾抚养他们。有一次，他们带她去探望“她丈夫”的坟墓——那是她从未认识过的男人。她

站在陌生的墓碑前献花，只觉得一切荒唐、无趣。她一边摆弄花束，一边烦恼：早知道骨灰别撒那么远，现在来悼念还得带地图。

Over and over it went. A young Jane emerged from a machine. She lived a life. She grew old, she either died or pre-empted it by redacting early. A young Jane emerged from a machine... By her second re-set the technology was mainstream. Redaction rode the back of fusion and became a technology for the masses. Jane's third iteration lived in a world where nearly half the population had been reset at least once.

这样的轮回上演了一次又一次。简从机器中走出，生活一段时间，然后老去，死亡，或选择提前回溯。到她第二次重置时，技术已被普及；到了第三次重置，全球已有近半数人口至少重启过一次人生。

So the cycle continued. Until we arrive back in the year 2351. Nine-minutes to midnight as the groan worthy fathers of this

time liked to joke.

就这样，轮回继续，直到时间来到2351年。这个时代的爹味段子手们总爱调侃：“离午夜还有九分钟。”

She had to quarantine before she could leave the facility that redacted her. Her microbes were from three-hundred and thirty years in the past. She may be carrying any number of viruses that were now thankfully eliminated.

按照公共健康条例，她必须在回溯中心完成隔离程序。毕竟，她体内的微生物来自三百三十年前，可能携带早已灭绝的病毒——这也是文明进化的代价之一。

While she was quarantined they showed her a video from some strange old woman who couldn't really explain what was happening clearly: her last iteration. Once the old woman who Jane couldn't think of as herself had finished her piece to camera a more professionally made video "re-oriented" her to the Earth of 2351.

在隔离期间，她被播放了一段来自“自己”的视频——一个陌生的老妇人，对着镜头絮絮叨叨地讲述人生，逻辑模糊、语气含混。那是她的“前世”。在那段录影结束后，一段由官方制作的导览视频播放，将她快速引入了2351年地球的现实。

Jane cried the first few nights. All her friends and family would now be dead or "de-synced" from her. With some digging around online she found she had a lot of descendants, children, and grandchildren all the way down to 3-greats.

头几晚，简夜夜以泪洗面。她的朋友、家人，要么早已作古，要么因回溯周期错位，变得毫无交集。她试着上网查找，发现自己竟然已经有子孙七代——孩子、孙辈、曾孙乃至玄孙。

Her email, bank account, and SocNet accounts had been set to "Bio-Authenticate" while she was reset. A small computer on wheels drove itself into her room and, after showing a lengthy legal disclaimer in video format, took a sample of blood from

a needle. Once the blood had been authenticated the machine allowed her to reset her passwords for her accounts.

她的邮箱、银行账号和社交账号都被设置为“生物认证”。一台小型机器滑进房间，播放一段旷长的法律免责声明视频后，用针头取了血样。身份认证通过后，她终于得以重设密码，重新登入现代生活。

Jane logged into her accounts.

简登录了她的各个账号。

First the email. Her inbox had been scrubbed clean. The only email was one sent the day before. It was from a daughter another version of her had had. It was a pleasantry, nothing more. "I hope the redaction is treating you well. If you are ever planning on being in Brazil please drop by." It seemed that meeting your mother as she was before she had you was not something you particularly sought out. Jane's sort-of-daughter seemed to be treating her as a not particularly close family member.

先是邮箱。收件箱被清得干干净净，唯一那封邮件是前一天发来的。发件人是平行时空里她曾有过的一个女儿。邮件内容只是客套寒暄："希望数据清理没给你添麻烦。要是哪天来巴西，记得来看看我。"看来遇见尚未成为你母亲时的她，并不是件让人特别期待的事。简这位"半个女儿"待她，就像对待一个不怎么亲近的远房亲戚。

Then the bank account. The amount of money was initially shocking, but she had failed to account for over three-hundred years of inflation. Accounting for this it became less "Bond villain holds world to ransom" value and a lot more "reasonable retirement fund".

接着查银行账户。起初那串数字令人瞠目，但她忘了算上三百多年的通货膨胀。这么一折算，金额就从"007 反派勒索全球"的级别，降到了"体面养老本"的水平。

Finally the SocNet. Like the email, scrubbed clean. Just a name, date of birth, and current age given as 83 (that needed correcting to account for the latest redaction).

最后是社交网络。和电子邮件一样，被清理得一干二净。只留下一个名字、出生日期和当前年龄，显示为 83 岁（这个数字需要根据最新的修订进行更正）。

Before Jane knew it her quarantine was completed and a taxi took her home. She found her flat, furnished in a Scandinavian style, wood painted pastel blue featured heavily as did gleaming steel radiators shaped like towel rails. The front door she opened with her SocNet account and a fingerprint.

简还没回过神来，隔离期就结束了。出租车载她回到公寓，推门看见北欧风装修——淡蓝色木饰面随处可见，毛巾架造型的钢制暖气片闪着冷光。她用社交网络账号配合指纹，“嘀”的一声打开了家门。

She found her bedroom, sat on the bed and wondered what the hell to actually do. Her old life was hundreds of years gone. She would not now go and do her university course (or had already done it she supposed), the friends and family she had

had were either permadead or so massively de-synced that they were basically other people.

她呆坐在卧室床沿，不知该从何开始。曾经的生活早已湮灭在数百年前：大学课程不必再修（或许早就修完了？），昔日的亲友不是永久逝去，就是被时光冲刷得面目全非。

Why the hell had her previous iteration done this to her?

上辈子的自己到底为什么要这样坑我？

Much later a red eyed Jane decided that she was now in this life. So she might as well do something with it.

直到双眼熬得通红，简终于想通：既然来都来了，不如活出点样子。

She walked around the flat that was apparently hers, giving it a proper look over. It looked "old fashioned" by modern standards, which meant that to Jane it looked very modern. It

was all so "old fashioned" in fact that it actually had some real, physical, paper "dead-tree" books.

她在显然是自己的公寓里转悠，仔细打量着四周。按现代标准这里"老派"得扎眼，但对简来说却新潮极了。事实上这里"复古"到还保留着真正的纸质书——那些"死树做成的老古董"。

To hell with it, start small. What was the name of the detective novel she had been reading under that tree? If it was here she might as well find out how it ended.

算了，别管那么多，先从小事做起吧。那本自己曾在树下读的侦探小说叫什么名字？如果它就在这里，那不如看看故事怎么收场。

The detective novel was indeed up on the shelf (not just the same edition from under the tree, but the same actual book). Jane lay diagonally across the best armchair, and started reading just where she had left off three-hundred-odd years ago, or a week ago subjectively.

那本侦探小说确实摆在书架上（不仅是同款，根本就是树下那本）。简斜躺进最舒服的扶手椅上，从三百年前——或者说，从她主观时间上不过一周前——中断的那一页接着读下去。

The book did her a lot of good. It connected her two lives. On finishing it Jane fell asleep where she was on the chair.

这本书给了她极大的安慰，它像一条线，把她的两段人生缝合起来。读完的时候，简就在那张椅子上睡着了，两个时空的记忆悄然交错，在梦里重叠。

Jane was woken up by the ringing of her doorbell. Checking the digital clock on the oven she saw it was midnight: who would be visiting?

简被门铃吵醒了。她瞥了一眼烤箱上的电子时钟——午夜整。这个点儿，谁会登门？

The doorbell rang again. The time between rings noticeably less than one "standard polite wait".

门铃再次响起，这次间隔短得明显不符合"礼貌等待"的常规。

She went to the door uncertainly. Who could it be? Should she open it?

她犹疑地走向门口，心里直打鼓：到底是谁？该不该开门？

The buzzer-machine had a camera that let her see the person outside. They were a woman of about Jane's age. The screen pinged up with a digital frame around their face, which identified them as "Name: Susan McLinty. Role: Great-Great-Granddaughter. - Verified by SocNet."

蜂鸣器机器上装有摄像头，能让她看清门外的人。那是一位与简年纪相仿的女性。屏幕上弹出一个数字边框框住了

她的脸，并显示识别信息：“姓名：苏珊·麦克林蒂。身份：曾曾孙女。——经社交网络验证。”

Jane let the other woman in.

简让这位女士进了门。

"Hey Gran-Gran." she said, opening her arms for a hug. Then she blinked at Jane and her arms dropped to her sides. "Oh, you redacted. Do-ya-know me?"

“外婆！”那女人张开双臂准备拥抱，刚要上前，又突然愣住，手臂尴尬地垂了下来。“啊，你是那种被系统屏蔽的人？你还记得我吗？”

Jane said she did not, but the system had marked her out as a relative.

简说不记得，但系统确实把她标成了亲属。

"Yeah, it would do. So, like ... I know this is a really weird thing to ask when we haven't met before in this iteration or anything, but ... I kind of got kicked out by my landlord and I, erm well ..."

"果然会这样...那个，虽然我们这轮人生从没见过面，但...我房东把我赶出来了，所以能不能..."

Jane offered Susan a place to stay. "I don't know if there is a spare bedroom though" she said.

简点头说可以，“不过我不太确定还有没有空房间。”

"There sure was a couple of years ago" said Susan with a big smile. "I retained some of my last stay, thought I would keep a little of my time with my Gran-Gran."

“肯定有的！”苏珊笑开了花，“我还留着上次来的记忆呢，总想多留点和外婆相处的时光。”

They found Susan's spare bedroom just as she expected it.
Then Susan showed Jane where her booze was.

果然，她们在公寓里找到了那间苏珊记忆中的客房。然后，苏珊领着简去找她藏的酒。

It seemed her previous iteration had been really into wine.
The wine was high-end stuff, but that was completely wasted
on Susan and Jane who selected bottles based off alcohol-%.

显然，简的前一个版本是个葡萄酒迷。架子上摆的都是高档货，可惜苏珊和简选酒的标准是“哪瓶度数高选哪个”。

Carrying a bottle each they headed to the living room and set
about the process of getting seriously drunk.

两人一人拎一瓶，晃进客厅，正式启动“酒精疗愈计划”。

"What! You have to read this bottle, its like ... so super
pretentious!" said Susan, "Aromas of nutmeg and sweet tones
evocative of lavender with a strong body."

“你快看看这瓶子上写的这些词，文艺得令人尴尬！”苏珊大笑着念道：“肉豆蔻香气，薰衣草余韵，酒体饱满，层次丰富……”

"Ha! My old iteration had expensive tastes maybe." said Jane. Then, thinking, "What was she like?"

"哈！看来我前世是个讲究人。"简说着说着突然走了神，"她到底是个什么样的人呢？"

"She was a nice lady. But like, she was seventy years old or something last I knew her. She let me crash with her for a while, I only retained a few days and she was pretty great those days. But, Jane, as much as I loved my Gran-Gran I could never drink like this with her! Should we get another bottle?"

"她是个特好的老太太。不过我们上次见面她都得七十多岁了。她收留我住过一阵子，虽然只记得相处的那几天，但真是段暖心日子。但是，简，w1o就算再爱我的老奶奶，我也没法跟她这么拼酒！要不咱们再开一瓶？"

Another bottle later and Susan entered the awkwardly thankful stage of drunkenness. She couldn't stop thanking Jane for letting her stay, and needed an arm under her to get her to bed.

又开了一瓶之后，苏珊进入了醉意朦胧又令人尴尬的“感恩环节”。她嘴里不停重复感谢简收留她，最后还得简扶着胳膊才能把她送上床。

"I can't believe he kicked me out. Bastard landlord." she muttered as Jane left her to bed.

"房东居然把我赶出来，王八蛋。"简安顿她睡觉时，她还在嘟嘟囔囔。

The next morning Jane and Susan continued to bond, this time over their hangovers. It seemed that Gran-Gran's posh taste in drink had poisoned them both.

第二天清晨，宿醉的简和苏珊继续培养祖孙感情。看来那位“奶奶”的高级品味差点把她俩害够呛。

The two of them sat at a stone kitchen top in Jane's old-fashioned/modern kitchen. A plate of toast and mug of tea each helped them recover. Over breakfast Jane asked Susan what had happened to get her kicked out of her home.

两人坐在厨房那张石制台面前，各自捧着吐司和茶水解酒。吃早餐时，简问苏珊到底是怎么被房东扫地出门的。

It took some explaining to get to the bottom of it.

费了好一番功夫才把这事儿彻底弄明白。

Susan was a day-counter. Like many people she had decided that she only had 70-100 odd years of hertime on earth. When that ran out she was gone, yes some new iteration of her could live but, that wasn't really her, or not this her.

苏珊属于那种“数日子过”的人。跟很多人一样，她觉得自己活在世上的“真实人生时间”大概就七八十年。等这些日子用完，她就算彻底没了。新一轮人生也许还会发生，但那已经不是“她”，至少不是现在这个她。

So anyway, she counted days. She kept a short-range redaction machine at home so that every night she could decide "was that day I just had worth spending one of my days of life on keeping?". If she decided "no" then she would redact it away.

于是，她开始每天计数。她家里有台“短程删改机”，每天晚上她都要盘一盘：这一天，值不值得花我人生的一天来记住？如果答案是“值了”，就保留；如果“不值”，就一键删除。

Her life was so alien that Jane struggled to wrap her head around it. Susan had worked at a cafe for the last 15 years, but had only retained a small part of the experience - times relating to essential training or particularly joyous work days.

It wasn't quite fair to say that for 15 years every day at work had been her first day (that would certainly get you fired!), but maybe every day had been in her first week.

她的生活模式，简真是越听越头大。苏珊在一家咖啡馆打工打了十五年，却只保留了其中为数不多的片段——要么是培训课程，要么是特别开心的工作日。说她十五年每天都像第一天上班有点夸张，但可能每天都像是试用期第一周。

As she pried into how it all worked Jane couldn't help but notice that Susan was, to put in bluntly: useless. She was physically 25 but was on her first iteration and had been born 75 years ago! Since leaving school less than 1 day in 5 met her standards for "keeping". She had, in some sense, experienced a half-century of Saturdays and skipped the rest. Jane wondered how much worse Susan suffered on the bad days for it. Her memories were all the best of the best days, so even a typical working day might hit her hard. The princess's first day working in the kitchens.

越聊越深入，简越发发现：这姑娘说白了就是个巨婴级职场废物。她肉体上25岁，但心理上还在第一轮活法里打滚——你信吗，这人已经出生75年了！自从毕业后，她平均五天里只有不到一天被自己认为“值得保留”。从某种意义上，她的人生就像是连续五十年的周末串烧，其它全跳过了。简不禁琢磨：那些她“剪掉”的烂日子，会不会其实更难熬？毕竟她记住的全是最顶配的好日子，导致哪怕是个普通工作日，都可能让她像个第一次进厨房的贵族公主一样手忙脚乱。

And then, after going through all that challenge, she would zap away the day and be exactly back where she had been the next morning. Princess's first day in the kitchens again, and again.

更惨的是：她辛辛苦苦熬完一天，结果第二天醒来一切重置——又是公主第一次进厨房。

Susan's recent crisis was new. Yesterday she had woken up to find a message from her past self telling her she had been

fired and didn't need to go to work. Then she realised with a shock that the message was six months old and her bank account was overdrawn. She hadn't paid rent in months.

苏珊最近的危机，是个新坑。昨天她一睁眼，就看到自己过去的某个版本留下的消息，说她被炒了，不用去上班了。但吓人的是，那消息的时间戳是六个月前。她的账户已经透支，房租几个月没交了。

Susan couldn't remember where the money had gone, but there had been enough empty bottles in her room to give some indication. She could check her card history, but had made a decision not to. Later that morning the landlord had, more or less, forced her into the street.

她不记得钱花哪去了，但屋子里堆满的空酒瓶已经把故事讲得差不多了。她本来可以查消费记录的，但她.....选择不查。当天上午，房东几乎是连人带行李一起扫地出门。

So here she was, what savings she had disappeared into some unremembered binge.

于是她就这么来了，所有的积蓄，都在她记不清的断片里蒸发了。

"So, when you say the machine you have at home is "short-ranged" what do you mean?" Jane asked.

“你说你家那台机器是‘短程’的，具体是多短？”简追问到。

"Oh, yeah, yeah. It can only send things back up to like 48 hours. Only got that much power."

“啊对，它最多能回溯四十八小时，功率也就撑这点。”苏珊说着，摆出那种“没啥大不了”的口气。

"But you could send something back 48 hours, then hit it again straight away for another 48 hours surely?"

"但你可以先回溯到 48 小时前，然后立刻再来一次 48 小时回溯对吧？"

Here Susan's eyes narrowed like she had only just realised that this whole world, the machines and everything about them, was a foreign country to Jane.

苏珊突然眯起眼睛，仿佛此刻才意识到，眼前这些机器连同整个世界，对简来说完全是个陌生领域。

"They don't work like that. After each use it takes 12 hours or something before it cools down."

"它们不能连续运作，每次使用后需要冷却 12 小时左右。"

"What if you cooled it faster?"

"要是加快冷却速度呢？"

"Well, it takes about the same time to recharge its capacitors from the mains. If it had a better electric supply and big

condensers to cool faster then it wouldn't be a "short ranged" redactor any more."

“也没用，还得给电容器充电，跟插电一样久。如果供电再牛一点、冷凝器再大一点，那它也就不是‘短程’删改机了。”

Later that day Jane helped Susan get her machine back from the bailiffs. It seemed an easy way to help, Susan clearly cared about it a great deal. It seemed that, in Susan's politics, the bailiffs taking the machine in the first place was an attack on her civil liberties and lifestyle choices. Getting the machine back was, she later felt, a huge mistake.

那天早些时候，简帮苏珊从法警那儿要回了机器。这本是举手之劳——苏珊显然把这机器看得比命还重。在苏珊的政治观念里，法警没收机器的行为根本是对她公民自由和生活方式的侵犯。但事后她才意识到，把机器要回来简直是个灾难性错误。

It was a coffin-like contraption with bedding inside, programmed to activate (if set to do so) while Susan was asleep, and set her back to another sleeping state (this did away with the unpleasantly abrupt transition). It was decorated in a style that was, by Jane's three-hundred year old standards, really tacky. By Susan's modern standards it was god-awful-tacky, but it was second hand and very cheap.

这个棺材般的装置内铺着褥子，设定能在苏珊睡着时自动启动（如果开启该功能），让她重新进入睡眠状态（这样就不会有难受的突然转换）。按简三百岁的审美标准，这机器的装饰风格简直俗不可耐。而以苏珊的现代眼光看，更是土到掉渣——不过毕竟是二手货，便宜得要命。

In addition to the coffin part of the machine was the condenser: a Dalek sized drum of metal connected to the main part by hose. Redaction produced a mean amount of heat. People were entropy factories and when their time got run back the universe demanded compensation - The Second Law would not be denied its dues. The machine contained over a hundred kilograms of water but the heat from back-

propagating Susan's constituent particles by just 24 hours vaporised it all.

除了“棺材主体”，机器还有个冷凝器，体积跟戴立克差不多大，用软管连着主机。删改记忆会产生巨量热能——毕竟人类是熵制造机，当你强行回溯一个人的时间线，宇宙是要来收税的。热力学第二定律说了算，欠的不可能不还。这玩意儿里面装了上百公斤的水，可哪怕只是让苏珊的身体回溯24小时，那桶水也能在几秒内被蒸干。

"Are you going to bankrupt me with electric bills?" asked Jane.

“你是想让我破产吗？光电费就够我卖房了。”简看着那机器问。

" "Electric bills"?!" That's the most pre-fusion thing I have ever heard!" answered Susan with a laugh. "Were they still burning dinosaurs in your time?"

“‘电费账单’？！”苏珊笑得前仰后合，“这听起来比我听过的所有老古董话题还古董！你们那会儿还在烧恐龙骨头发

电吗？”

With her machine returned to her Susan returned to a pattern of redacting away every single day. She was still unemployed, out of a home and unhappy, so she zapped the days away. Zap, zap, zap. The knock-on was that Jane had almost the same conversations with her everyday - super boring.

拿回机器的苏珊恢复了每天删除日子的习惯。她依然无业游民、居无定所，于是机械地点击着删除键——咔、咔、咔。结果就是简每天和她重复着几乎相同的对话，无聊透顶。

Jane made a conscious effort to think about what she wanted to do in this life. Doing some research on her previous iterations she found that all of them had decided to take the route that paid bills, none had really properly followed the philosophy angle she had been half-considering at Uni. This time round she had quite a lot left over from "Gran Gran", and no inheritance tax ("Inheritance tax? No, no, no. You are the

same person." said the man from the bank when she asked).
She could afford to take a bit of risk.

简决定认真思考这一生到底想做点什么。翻查了过往版本的履历后发现，每一个“她”都选择了务实路线，全都为了交账单而活，从来没人真正走过她大学时一度心动的哲学方向。这一回，她继承了“老奶奶”的一大笔资产，而且根本不用交遗产税——当她疑惑地去问银行时，对方只是耸耸肩：“遗产税？没有的事，你和这个奶奶是同一个人啊。”她这次终于有条件冒一点险了。

She had been redacted back to before she had fully finished her uni course, but apparently people were surprisingly happy to give you the benefit of qualifications you didn't remember getting, so long as it was nothing vocational like law or medicine.

虽然技术上她现在是被回溯到了大学尚未毕业的状态，但人们惊人地愿意承认她那些“记不得”的学历——只要不是法律或医学这类必须实操的行业，基本都能蒙混过关。

In any case she could do a short online catch-up course that would give her a new certificate for this iteration.

实在不行她也可以上个在线速成班，拿个新版本的资格证，填补这轮人生的“文凭空白”。

It was something to do and that was worth a lot. She video chatted with course mates about the syllabus and life in general. Most of them were recent redacts, but the others found the world less crazy than Jane. She was the only one born pre-machine. The others had all grown up half-expecting to find themselves thrown randomly into the future at some point.

总之，有事可做，这本身就已经价值千金了。她开始和课程同学视频聊天，既聊课程安排，也谈谈各自的近况。大多数人都是刚刚进行过记忆删改的新版本，尽管如此，大家普遍觉得这个世界没简想得那么荒唐。毕竟，只有她是“机器时代”之前出生的古董人类，其他人从小就知道未来会不定时随机刷新——人生只不过是一次大规模盲盒活动。

One particular online lecture really stood out for Jane. It was about redaction machines.

有一节课特别让简印象深刻，主题正是“记忆修正装置”。

The nub of the idea was a thought experiment. Suppose someone is kidnapped and is told that the following will happen to them. First they are shown a countdown. When it reaches zero they will then be tortured painfully to death (why did people always make these things so gruesome? thought Jane). Once they have died they will be redacted back, to their exact state at the end of the countdown (just as the number hit zero) and set free.

讲师提出了一个思想实验：想象你被绑架了，对方告诉你接下来会发生的事——你会看到一个倒计时器。当它归零时，你将被活活折磨至死（简内心吐槽：“这些哲学实验为什么都非得搞得这么血腥？”）。但在死亡瞬间，你会被机器回溯回那个“倒计时刚刚归零”的状态，然后获释。

What does the person in this situation feel as the clock ticks down? What should the person feel? What should they feel when they see the number hit zero and find that they are still in the torture chamber? What should they feel if they instead find themselves jumped forwards in time as the countdowns ends? What probability do they assign to the chance of them finding themselves in one branch or the other?"

问题是——你在倒计时逐秒减少的过程中，会有什么感觉？你应该有什么感觉？如果归零后，你发现自己还在那间刑讯室，该怎么理解？如果相反，你发现自己直接跳跃到了未来，那这算是真实的逃脱，还是随机的幸运？你要如何估算，自己到底会落入哪个时间分支？

To Jane the answer seemed obvious.

对简来说，答案显而易见。

"It's 50/50." she said. "It's no different from a coin toss. There are going to be two copies of you, but at different times. One will suffer, the other not. So if you see that it hits zero you

know you were unlucky and will be disappointed. If you find yourself transition at that moment then you know you are the other iteration, the lucky one. You have escaped. You would be relieved."

"五五开吧。"她说道，"这和抛硬币没区别。会出现两个不同时间线的你，一个受苦一个解脱。如果看到计时归零，就知道自己倒霉该沮丧；要是瞬间穿越了，那就是幸运版本的你成功逃脱，当然会长舒一口气。"

"OK." smiled the lecturer through the screen of Jane's computer, clearly getting ready for her punchline. "If that was 50/50 Jane, then back when you were in childhood, what chance should you assign to you finding yourself as the copy of you that experiences the life of your first iteration?"

「有意思。」电脑屏幕中的讲师露出玩味的笑容，显然酝酿着关键的反问，「既然你说是五五开，简，那么回到你的童年时，你认为自己最终成为第一个人生版本的概率又是多少呢？」

"Well, I have been redacted four times. So one in five." Jane answered.

“唉，我已经被删改过四次，所以五次里才会有一次。”简答道。

"But that is only so far! Do you intend to have future iterations? How many more? Has the number of iterations you will have already been predetermined?"

“但那只是目前的情况！你还计划继续迭代吗？要改多少次？难道迭代次数早已注定？”

Jane thought long and hard about the thought experiment afterwards. She couldn't really work out the right way of thinking about it. If the redaction machine were replaced by a hypothetical replication machine then she thought it was easy. After replication there were two exact copies of her. Both would have all her exact memories. But they would diverge in experience thereafter. She would find herself as one of the two, either stepping out of the replication machine or standing

outside the machine watching the copy step out. It was, she thought, clearly a 50/50 probability in this case which one she would find herself to be.

之后，简反复琢磨这个思想实验，越想越迷惑。如果把删改机换成复制机，事情就简单多了——复制后会出现两个完全相同的她，记忆一致但经历不同。她可能会成为从复制机里走出来的自己，也可能成为在外面注视克隆体走出来的那个自己。这种情况显然是五五开的概率。

But with the redaction it became harder. How many copies were there? How many young Janes would emerge from machines in the far future? Jane's rudimentary understanding of the philosophy of probability didn't seem to help. The frequentist got doubly lost in nonlocality over time. And Jane wasn't sure being subjective about probability helped much. How many redactions did she expect?

但涉及记忆删改时，事情变得复杂。到底有多少个副本？在遥远的未来，会诞生多少年轻的简？她粗浅的概率哲学知识无济于事，频率派理论在跨时空的非定域性中更加混

乱。至于主观概率？她也无法确定自己究竟预期多少次删改。

Susan was still really annoying. When the wine ran out she started pestering Jane about borrowing money to buy drink. Jane refused, knowing that Susan had no chance of retaining the experience of borrowing money to drown her sorrows yet again.

苏珊还是一如既往地令人烦躁。酒喝完之后，她开始缠着简借钱买酒。简一口回绝，因为她知道苏珊重复这种借酒浇愁的经历不会带来任何改变。

By now they had lived together for weeks. But for Susan waking up suddenly unemployed, broke and homeless had only happened yesterday. She needed some time to feel sorry for herself, to get blind drunk. To vent a little.

迄今为止，她们已经共同生活了好几周，但对苏珊来说，突然醒来发现自己失业、破产并无家可归，这一切就像昨

天才发生一样。她需要一点时间自怨自艾，需要借酒消愁，需要发泄情绪。

But she had done all that a hundred times, nearly thirty times here with Jane, and who knew how many times at home before that. It was an experience she hated and had chosen a hundred times not to retain. She was a fool and a pathetic one. Her weedy grovelling for booze-money from Jane interrupted her lessons. She asked the same way, with almost the same words every single day. Susan didn't have the perspective to see what a deep rut she was in. For her this was day two in Jane's flat, she was still waking up with the same hangover that "Gran Gran's" wine had given them both that first night.

可这些行为苏珊已重复了上百次，光和简相处期间就有近三十次，更不用说之前的次数。这种经历她憎恶至极，却一再选择遗忘。她的愚昧与悲哀令人心烦，每日乞讨酒钱的请求总以同样的话语重复。她无法觉察自己已深陷循环。对她而言，这只是住进简公寓的第二天，宿醉的感觉还是第一晚葡萄酒留下的后遗症。

At first Jane found it simply inexplicable - how could Susan be so stupid? It took time to understand. Susan had rejected the idea that a miserable day might be necessary as a general stance years ago. More recently, she had decided that this specific awful experience wasn't one to keep - and that was a decision she made once again for the first time every day.

起初，简难以理解苏珊怎么会如此愚蠢。后来她渐渐明白，多年前苏珊就拒绝承认糟糕的日子可能是必要的。最近，她又决定这种痛苦的经历无需保留，这个决定每天都要重新做一次，就像首次面对一样。

On Jane's day two she had gone supermarket shopping to stock the house. She had asked Susan what she liked and bought her favourite cereal. Jane couldn't eat it as she was allergic to nuts, but it was Susan's favourite. For the next twenty days, at about midday, she heard the words "Hey, Jane, it must run in the family, this is my favourite cereal too!" shouted up the stairs to her. Announcing that Susan was

awake and would do the whole "What you doing?", "Oops, sorry for interrupting your online lesson thingy" routine any minute.

简搬进来的第二天，曾特意问苏珊喜欢吃什么，买了她最爱的坚果麦片——尽管自己因过敏无法食用。之后的二十多天，每到中午苏珊都会兴奋地喊：「简，这麦片肯定是家族遗传，我也超爱吃的！」随即又开始她每日例行的「你在忙啥呢？」和「哎呀，又打扰你上网课了吧？」

Jane thought it was bad when Susan drank. Now the wine was out it was worse. The wheedling, the arguing. Jane was not supposed to be responsible for an alcoholic on a loop.

当酒精耗尽后，苏珊变本加厉，软磨硬泡、争吵不休。简并没有义务像陀螺般围绕着一个酒鬼旋转。

Of course she tried to persuade Susan not to use her machine. But there are only so many ways of having that conversation and all were exhausted unsuccessfully by week two.

当然，她曾试图劝说苏珊别再使用记忆机，但所有的劝说在第二周就彻底失效了。

Then it happened. One day Jane's slowly fraying temper snapped. Susan had just started stepping sideways towards the idea of "getting some drinks to have this evening" like she always did, when Jane lost it. She shouted at Susan. She screamed and stamped and swore at her. Susan fled crying to her room.

终于有一天，简压抑的怒火爆发了。苏珊再次暗示要买酒喝时，简彻底失控，对苏珊吼叫怒骂，直到她哭着逃回房间。

Jane slept terribly, she felt so guilty. The version of Susan she had screamed at had not yet started wheedling and begging in that infuriating way. Although she had once again been on that trajectory.

当晚简因愧疚辗转反侧。第二天清晨，她忐忑地在苏珊房门前放了杯热茶，忐忑不安地等待回应。

The next morning Jane sheepishly put a mug of tea outside Susan's bedroom. Then waited in the kitchen, feeling cold and stiff, wondering if Susan would accept the apology. Or would she be angry?

第二天清晨，简局促不安地把茶杯放在苏珊卧室门口。她在厨房僵立等待，手脚冰凉，心里打着鼓：苏珊会接受这份歉意，还是勃然大怒？

Susan couldn't remember it. She had zapped the episode away. Today was exactly the same for her. Jane's outburst had made absolutely no difference to anything.

苏珊根本不记得这茬。她早把这段记忆删得干干净净。对她而言今天毫无异样，简的爆发就像拳头打在棉花上。

Jane didn't lose her temper again for another week. But she did lose it again. Susan was always shocked when Jane lost it.

She always started babbling and crying and soon fled to her room. She always redacted and forgot all about it.

简勉强撑了一周没再发作，可最终还是破了功。每次简失控时，苏珊总像受惊的兔子——先是语无伦次地哭闹，转眼就躲回房间。更绝的是，她事后总会把整件事从记忆里一键清空。

Jane had been working so hard to keep her temper. For what? It made literally no difference if she spent the whole day being nice to Susan or not. She could buy her the coveted drinks. They could relive some near-clone of Susan's second day - a dreadfully dull experience for Jane. Or Jane could take the easy route, not bother to contain her frustration. Her parents were dead. Her uni housemates that she lived with just two months ago, from her perspective, dead. Friends: dead. She didn't know the world outside her flat, it was too strange and terrifying. And to top it all off she lived with a drunk who was annoying in the same way every day.

简一直拼命压抑自己的脾气。可这有什么意义？无论她整天对苏珊和颜悦色还是冷眼相对，结果根本毫无差别。她可以给苏珊买心心念念的饮料，两人重温苏珊第二天经历的翻版——对简来说简直是折磨。或者她也可以选择轻松点，任由怒火爆发。父母双亡，两个月前还同住的大学室友在她看来也已阴阳两隔，朋友们都不在了。公寓外的世界陌生得可怕。最糟的是，她还得每天面对那个醉鬼，用千篇一律的方式惹人厌烦。

The thing that made it inevitable was the lack of consequence. Each time Jane's frustration came out as shouting and screaming that sent Susan running away in tears it changed nothing. Jane became quicker to anger, harsher in her shouting. It wasn't at all planned, but one day she let go of herself so much that she slapped Susan. Shocked even more than normal, Susan fled to her room crying.

真正令事态无可挽回的，是那些发泄从不需要付出代价。每当简冲着苏珊大吼大叫，把她骂得哭着逃走，第二天一切又恢复如初。简的脾气变得愈发暴躁，言语也越来越刻

薄。直到有一天，她完全失控，扇了苏珊一记耳光——这远远超出了以往的界限，吓得苏珊哭着躲回了房间。

The next morning saw another cup of tea at Susan's door. A sleepless Jane trying to work out how to say sorry.

次日清晨，苏珊房门前又摆着一杯热茶。一夜未眠的简正在苦苦思索，该如何向她道歉。

Another oblivious Susan with no memory of the event.

而懵懂的苏珊，却好像什么都不记得了。

One day the doorbell rang. It was the first time it had rang since Susan herself had arrived nearly three months ago.

直到某天门铃突然响起——这可是苏珊搬来三个月头一遭。

Jane looked at the entry screen thing. "Name: Lillian Morgen. Role: Police Officer. - Verified by MET Police."

简盯着门口的身份核验屏幕：“姓名：莉莲·摩根；身份：警官。——伦敦警署认证”。

Jane felt a flutter of fear, but she couldn't work out why, so forced it away. She let the police in, two officers and a social worker. They verified her identity and that Susan lived with her.

简心头掠过一阵莫名的惶恐，却说不出缘由，只能勉强压下。她打开房门，迎进两名警官与一名社工。他们核验了她的身份，并确认苏珊与她同住。

Then they arrested Jane, took her to a police car and then a police station. She was shocked and terrified. A part of her knew what it was, but she suppressed that part ferociously. She had done nothing wrong she screamed in her mind.

接着，警察竟然突然逮捕了简，将她押进警车，带往警局。她震惊不已，又害怕极了。心底隐隐知道缘由，却疯狂地抗拒着那个念头。她在心里尖叫：“我根本没有做错任何事！”

She found herself in a small room with a mirror that probably doubled as a window. Three cameras looked at her and the police woman, a forty-something woman with rower's shoulders, took a seat across from her. The police woman began explaining the situation to Jane.

简被带进了一间狭小的审讯室，一面镜子显然是一扇单向玻璃。三台摄像头齐齐盯着她。那位女警——四十来岁，肩膀厚实如同赛艇运动员一般——坐在对面，开始向她解释状况。

"First, I would like to remind you that, by law, all redaction machines take a medical scan of their occupant immediately before activation. A record of the person before they back

propagate." The woman looked at Jane and she felt her stomach sinking.

“首先提醒你，根据法律，所有记忆消除机在启动前都会对使用者进行医学扫描，以保留回溯前的原始记录。”女警目光紧盯着简，令她感到胃里一阵翻腾。

"Why?" asked Jane. "What have I been arrested for? Do I not get a lawyer or something?"

“为什么？”简质问道，“我到底犯了什么罪？我连律师都不能请吗？”

"The system", she indicated the cameras, "has got every approved lawyer installed. You can access any of them for advice using an interface later. For now though any of them are able to interrupt if it will help you. I will explain the nature of the charges against you, so that you can make an informed choice." The woman gave Jane a hard look.

“系统里，”女警指了指摄像头，“已经预装了所有认证律师的资料。稍后你可以通过界面咨询他们，现在若有必

要，他们也会随时介入。”女警用严厉的目光盯着她继续说道，“我会先说明对你的指控，以便你做出知情的选择。”

"These medical records are transmitted to a central police database. It is to preserve a record of crimes committed against victims who are later redacted. Things like murder, violence, sexual assault ... and domestic abuse." Jane may have been projecting, but she felt like those last words were thrown at her with unhidden disgust.

“医疗扫描记录会上传至警方中央数据库，以保存针对记忆被消除的受害者的犯罪证据，比如谋杀、暴力、性侵……”她刻意加重了最后几个字的语气，“以及家庭暴力。”简并不确定这是否是自己的心理作用，但女警的语气中分明带着毫不掩饰的鄙夷。

Jane didn't argue out loud, she was too busy arguing inside. Her stomach felt cold and seemed to sink right through her chair down to the floor. She hadn't abused Susan ... had she?

She had lost her temper sometimes, shouted at her. Her hand tingled with the memory of slapping Susan. OK so there had been that one time, or was it two? There was the time she had kicked her as well. Wait, that might have been more than once as well. It all blurred together.

简没有出声反驳，她正忙着和内心激烈斗争。胃部冰冷，仿佛整个人都要沉进地板里。她真的没有虐待过苏珊吗？确实有时控制不住情绪吼过她，手掌也还记得扇过苏珊耳光的麻痛感。没错，那次——也许不止一次？还有踹她的记忆。等等，似乎也不止一次？所有的回忆交织成一团，模糊而令人恐惧。

She partly returned to the interrogation room. She heard some of what was being said. Read to her from a tablet computer.

她恍惚地回到现实中，隐约听见女警在平板上逐条念出的指控。

"... December 13th: Bruising to lower torso. December 14th: Split lip, torso bruising again..."

"12月13日：下腹部淤青。12月14日：嘴唇开裂，腹部再次出现淤伤..."

Jane couldn't believe it. She was a good person. Yes she sometimes, very rarely, lost her temper because Susan was so infuriating but she would never ... but she had. The medical files said so. It was like the world was wrong somehow. And Jane's memories were also wrong for some reason and, and ...

简简直无法接受这些事实。她本来是个好人！虽然偶尔——真的只是偶尔——她会因为苏珊过于激怒自己而失控，但她绝对不会……然而医疗记录不会撒谎。整个世界仿佛扭曲了，连自己的记忆都变得不可靠了……

Jane felt sick. Oh hell what had she done?!

简感到一阵恶心。天啊，她到底做了些什么？！

She looked up into the face of the police woman. She took a deep breath. She deserved this. She would deny nothing. She

would admit it. At least, she would once she got to the end of the information and had the chance to check it all with her digital lawyers.

她抬起头望着女警的脸，深吸了一口气。这是她应得的，她不会否认。她决定坦白一切——至少在看完资料，征求过数字律师意见之后。

The police woman disappeared. So did the interrogation room. Even the handcuffs.

但女警却忽然消失了，审讯室也随之消散，甚至手铐也没了踪影。

Jane suddenly found herself in a familiar type of machine. Once again she lay in a bath of fatty liquid, the surplus mass that some future version of her had shed while propagating backwards. Once more overall clad technicians came to check she was healthy. Her confession was frozen on the tip of her tongue.

简猛然发现自己又回到了那台熟悉的机器里。她浸泡在脂肪液体中——那是她未来的某个版本回溯时脱落的物质。身穿连体服的技术人员前来检查她的健康，而她的供词却僵硬地凝在了舌尖。

She was led to a shower where she washed off the remains of her future self. Jane then dressed in the provided clothes and made her way out to the new-new-world she found herself in.

她被领到淋浴间冲洗掉未来自己的残留物，换上准备好的衣服，走向这个崭新的新世界。

Her admission felt solid in her throat. So heavy that it felt almost like it was constricting her breathing.

她的坦白依旧沉重地堵在喉咙口，让她几乎喘不过气。

Outside the shower room she was greeted by a uniformed man.

淋浴间外，一名制服男子迎上前来。

"When did you come from?" he asked.

“你是从哪儿来的？”他问。

"I, it was, in the police station."

“我刚刚.....在警察局。”简迟疑地答道。

"OK. What year?" he asked, inviting her to take a seat in a small office. He took the seat across the desk from her, like some office-y shadow of that police interrogation room.

“好的。是哪一年？”他请简在办公室里坐下，自己则坐在桌子对面，仿佛审讯室的职场翻版。

"Twenty three, fifty-something I think." Answered Jane.

“二十三世五十几年吧，我记不太清了。”简有些茫然。

The man frowned at her uncertainty, surprised she didn't know the year.

男人听到她含糊的回答，皱起了眉头，似乎惊讶于她竟连年份都说不清楚。

"I hadn't been there very long. I was in 2021 then some other time hundreds of years later. Then I was in the police station and then here."

“我在2021年没待多久，就一下子穿越到了几百年后。然后去了警察局，再之后就到了这里。”

The man looked at a tablet computer, bringing back more memories of the police station only half an hour ago.

男子低头查看了一眼手中的平板电脑，这动作又勾起了简半小时前在警察局的记忆。

"Yes. I am very sorry about this. We had a solar flare. We think it set off an electrical surge and threw off the system

calibration. We missed our target time by a few months it looks like, maybe half a year at the outside."

“是的，这件事我们深感抱歉。当时遇到了太阳耀斑，很可能引发了电流冲击，导致系统校准偏离了目标时间。从目前情况来看，我们错过了目标时间几个月，最多可能偏差了半年。”

"What were you aiming for?" asked Jane.

“你们原本计划抵达什么时候？”简追问道。

"Your file just gives a date, hour and minute. You told me before you went in that you always reset to that exact same moment. You said it meant a lot to you. I am really, very sorry that we missed it. There will be compensation of course."

“你的档案只记录了具体的日期、小时和分钟。你之前告诉我们，每次都会重置到那个特定时刻，因为那对你意义重大。我们真的非常抱歉没能准确抵达。当然，这方面会有相应的补偿。”

She wondered if they would lock her up when they worked out they had a Jane who had done a crime but not yet done the time. Presumably some past Jane had gone to prison. Did that mean she was off the hook? Was that fair?

简心中一阵忐忑：如果他们意识到这里有个犯了罪却尚未服刑的简，会不会把她重新关起来？也许在某个过去的版本里，她早已坐过牢了。那么，她现在是不是就算逃过了一劫？这样又是否公平呢？

"I feel sick", Jane said.

“我感觉有点难受。”简轻声说道。

"Don't worry. That is just the Coriolis, you haven't adapted yet to spin gravity."

“别担心，这只是科里奥利效应而已。你还没有适应这里的旋转模拟重力。”

"Spin gravity?"

“旋转重力？”

"Sorry, I am giving you this in all the wrong order. The current year is 1321 PD - Post Departure", he looked at his tablet, "that puts it about 5,700 AD. You are aboard the space habitation Derbyshire 4. For context Derbyshire 4 is one of several million habitats orbiting the star Groombridge."

"抱歉我说得有点乱。现在是 PD 纪元 1321 年——也就是'大撤离后'，他看了眼平板，"换算成公元纪年大约是 5700 年。你现在身处太空居住站'德比郡四号'上。简单来说，德比郡四号是环绕格鲁姆布里奇恒星的数百万个居住站之一。"

Jane hadn't yet adapted to one future but now she was in another, far more distant one. At some point thousands of years after her arrest some iteration of Jane had enrolled in a colony program.

简连之前的那个未来都尚未完全适应，此刻却又置身于一个更加遥远陌生的未来。在她被捕之后的数千年间，某个版本的简选择报名参加了一项星际殖民计划。

As the first step of interstellar travel, she had been given a lethal injection. Then her corpse had been liquefied and sealed in a tin can. The resulting slop had cruised through the void between stars for a thousand years. Her remains either frozen by the cold of interstellar space, boiled by the heat of the atomic rockets or a bit of both depending on where on the ship they were stowed.

作为星际旅行的第一步，她接受了一次致命注射，随即她的尸体被液化并密封在金属容器里。这团液态残骸在星际的虚空中漂流了整整一千年。在这漫长旅途中，她的遗体有时被星际的严寒冻结，有时被原子火箭的高温煮沸，或者兼而有之，具体状态取决于存放在飞船的哪个位置。

Then, on arrival at the star system Groombridge, a redaction machine had whirled to life. Hundreds of years of being

frozen porridge was wound backwards and the Jane that had sat in a clinic back on Earth awaiting the lethal injection had awoken at Groombridge. Instantaneous interstellar travel, at least subjectively.

当抵达格鲁姆布里奇星系时，一台记忆重构机嗡嗡启动，将数百年来呈冷冻肉泥状态的遗骸逆向还原。于是，那个曾在地球诊所里等待致命注射的简，再度睁开了双眼——至少在她的主观感受里，这次星际旅行瞬间便完成了。

The planetoids of Groombridge were no good for living, nor had anyone thought they might be. They were small and airless, their feeble gravities insufficient to hold even the lightest breath of atmosphere. These same gravities were also what made them valuable, their shallow potential wells meant no great effort was needed to harvest them. They gave up their iron, silicon and water ice without resistance. With these commodities the colonists built artificial homes. Spinning cylinders with gravity, warmth, sunlight and all the comforts of home. They had hundreds of acres of "land" per head, an

abundance that Jane gathered would make the poor sardines back in the Sol system green with envy.

格鲁姆布里奇星系的类行星天体并不适合居住，人们也从未奢望过它们能宜居。这些天体体积微小，没有空气，微弱的引力甚至不足以维持哪怕最稀薄的大气。然而，这种微不足道的引力恰恰是它们的价值所在：浅薄的引力并意味着开采资源无需耗费太大能量，铁、硅与水冰轻易便能获取。殖民者们利用这些材料建造了人工栖息地：旋转的圆柱形空间站，模拟出重力，带来温暖与阳光，拥有地球家园般的舒适与安逸。这里人均享有数百英亩的“土地”，如此宽裕的空间令简不禁想到，太阳系中那些拥挤如沙丁鱼的人们见到一定会嫉妒得眼红。

They did not lock Jane up.

然而，他们并没有将简关押起来。

She found that she was a celebrity of some kind. Maybe even an informal leader. She came from Sol, unlike the great majority of the population who had been born at this end. This

alone afforded a certain cachet. She was seen as one of the pioneers, seen almost like the American pilgrim fathers had been back in Jane's time.

简发现自己居然成了某种名人，甚至某种意义上的非正式领袖。与绝大多数本地出生的居民不同，她来自遥远的太阳系，仅凭这一点便为她赢得了无上的尊敬。人们将她视作一位开拓者，几乎如同简那个时代的人们看待漂洋过海的“清教徒先驱”一样。

On top of that she was the only person in Groombridge with a birth pre-2,000 AD date of birth (if barely). Her last few iterations seemed to have made this into a career. She had done videos, interviews, lectures and after dinner speeches. People were electrified by the thought that she had been born in the same millennium as Napoleon Bonaparte and William the Conqueror.

更特别的是，她还是格鲁姆布里奇星系唯一一个出生于公元2000年之前的人（虽然也仅仅早了一点点而已）。在最近几次人生迭代中，她似乎已将这一身份发展成了一种职

业，拍摄视频、接受采访、举办讲座和晚宴致辞。每当人们意识到，她居然与拿破仑和征服者威廉生于同一个千年，都会兴奋得两眼放光。

Initially Jane was too busy adapting to the world around her to give much time to her guilty conscience. But eventually it returned. Her near-confession returned to her throat, choking her so much she sometimes hyperventilated. Her stomach would sink when she thought about how she had gotten away with it. The guilt increased until at last she sought out a police station to hand herself in.

最初，简全神贯注地适应周围的陌生世界，以至于无暇顾及心底的负罪感。但最终，那种负罪感还是卷土重来了。未曾出口的坦白始终堵在喉咙里，沉重得令她时常呼吸困难。每当想到自己竟能逍遥法外，她便感到胃里一阵绞痛。这种痛苦不断累积，终于迫使她下定决心，亲自前往警局自首。

A chirpy young policeman was happy to take her into his office to talk. He offered her a selection of hot drinks and biscuits. A lump caught in Jane's throat as she tried to say what had happened. In the end she handed the policeman the confession she had intended to read out.

一名活泼开朗的年轻警察热情地将她迎进办公室，甚至贴心地为她准备了热饮和饼干。简试图将自己的遭遇亲口讲出，却发现喉咙堵塞得难以发声。最终，她只得将那份事先写好的供述递给了对方。

The young man started reading with a frown. He swallowed nervously on finishing it and handed it back without making eye contact.

年轻警察皱起眉头，开始仔细阅读起来。看完后，他紧张地咽了一口口水，没有与简对视，便将那份供述还给了她。

"Miss, the authorities back on, what was the name of the Habitat?"

“小姐，你提到的那个居住地叫什么来着？”

"Earth."

"地球。"

"Right. Wait? Like, Earth, Earth? The planet?" the policeman let out a breath in awe. "Well that is way out of our jurisdiction."

“对，等等……你是说，地球？那个真正的地球——行星？”警察震惊地倒吸一口气，“那完全超出了我们的管辖范围啊。”

"But, I had already been arrested. I was about to admit it! I just needed a few more minutes..."

“可我明明已经被逮捕了！我当时就要坦白了！只差那么几分钟……”简激动地说道。

"We can't arrest you for a crime you claim to have committed thousands of years ago in another solar system." said the policeman with a serious smile. "We can check your records if you like. When you pioneers came out here they brought everything written about any of you for the psychographic engineering."

警察带着严肃而又礼貌的微笑解释道：“我们没办法因为你自称在数千年前、另一个恒星系犯下的罪行而逮捕你。不过如果你愿意，我们倒是可以查阅一下你的档案。当年你们这些先驱者移民过来的时候，心理工程部门把你们每个人的相关记录都带来了。”

He typed and clicked a little at a computer. Then invited her around to look at the screen.

他在电脑上快速敲打了几下，然后示意简走过去查看屏幕。

"See, look. Sentence served. You plead guilty and served your time." he pointed at some notes on his screen, "They let you out early for good behaviour on the condition you agreed not to redact the sentence away."

“你看这里，刑期已经执行完毕了。你当时认罪并服满了刑期，”他指着屏幕上的记录说道，“你因为表现良好而提前获释，但条件是不允许篡改这段刑罚的记录。”

"But I did!" said Jane. "There was a solar flare. They got the times wrong. They sent me back to before I had done the sentence."

“可是我真的篡改了！”简急切地争辩道，“当时发生了太阳耀斑，导致他们搞错了时间，把我送回了执行刑罚之前。”

"It doesn't matter, miss. We have been outside the jurisdiction of ..." he scrolled down the form and pointed, "The United ... Oh wow!" he turned back to look at her, "You lived in a Kingdom?!"

“这已经不重要了，女士。我们早就脱离了……”警察边说边向下翻阅屏幕上的记录，“联合……天呐！”他忽然惊讶地抬起头盯着简，“你居然来自一个‘王国’？！”

Jane could practically see the battlements and knights in the policeman's eyes.

简甚至能从警察瞪大的眼睛里看到中世纪城堡与骑士的身影。

The policeman was happy to show Jane how to access her personal records about her previous lives. Looking them over she learned that ever since 2351 every single iteration of Jane had started her new life from some time a few days after leaving prison. They had all kept the sentence, they had chosen to hand it down the chain for millennia even after it was no longer required. Almost every Jane to have ever existed remembered living out that spell in prison.

年轻警察很高兴地向简展示如何查阅她前世的个人档案。通过查阅记录，简惊讶地发现，自从2351年以来，她的每

一次转世都是在服刑期满后几天才开启新的生活的。那些“简们”一直铭记着那段刑期，甚至在法律早已不再要求时，仍将那段记忆像接力棒一样传递了数千年。几乎每一个曾经存在过的简，都清晰地记得自己坐过的那段牢狱时光。

Until now. She did not. The first in thousands of years. Those memories were gone now. No future Jane would have them ever again.

直到现在，她却没有了这些记忆了。几千年来，这是头一遭。那些牢狱记忆如今彻底消失，未来任何版本的简，也不再会拥有它们了。

She reflected on this on her walk home. The route felt strangely like the towpath back home. The horizon wasn't right obviously, instead of vanishing into the distance it reared up, looped over and joined up with the horizon behind. It wasn't a canal she walked beside, it was a floor-window. A big piece of glass (or more likely some futuristic clear material)

that allowed the bright light of Groombridge into the habitat. With the spinning, the light was very inconstant, turning smoothly between illumination from above, in front, below and behind. Yes the window wasn't at all a canal, but somehow the path along its edge felt like the towpath.

回家的路上，她心不在焉地思考着这件事。这条路不知为何总让她想起家乡的运河纤道。然而这里的地平线显然不同寻常：它并未向远方延伸，而是弯曲着向上回卷，最终与背后的地平线交汇。她行走的路径旁也并非真正的运河，而是一扇镶嵌在地板上的观景窗——一整块巨大的透明材料，将格鲁姆布里奇恒星的明亮光线引入居住舱。伴随空间站的旋转，光影不停流转，从头顶、眼前、脚下再到身后。是的，尽管它绝非运河，但沿着窗边漫步的感觉，竟与过去熟悉的纤道如此相似。

It was approaching the time Jane thought of as "midnight". The time when the sun (technically star) was below Jane's feet. No "daylight" came from above, but the canal seemed to catch fire. The prismatic glass directed the light upwards, to illuminate the people on the cylinder's far side. The

refractions the glass made were designed for them. The golden, fire-like glow Jane saw was just the inefficiency.

接近她称之为“午夜”的时刻了。此时，恒星正好位于她脚下，头顶再无天光，但那扇“运河”般的观景窗却仿佛燃起了火焰一般耀眼的光芒。折射式的玻璃将光线向上引导，为圆柱居住站另一侧的人们提供照明。而她所看到这火焰般绚丽的金色辉光，不过是光学折射设计中的无意损耗罢了。

A few minutes later "midday" spun around. The windows on Derbyshire's far side glowed bright above Jane's head and sunlight came streaking down through the trees. The "canal" was black, apart from the stars. So many stars, the Milky Way floating in the canal.

几分钟后，“正午”旋转而至。德比郡空间站对侧的窗户在筒头顶亮起，阳光穿透树木倾洒下来。“运河”则漆黑如墨，只剩漫天繁星，甚至可以看到银河如一条闪烁的光带，静静流淌其中。

This place certainly had its charms thought Jane. Before catching herself in the thought. Is that who she was? Someone who would just shrug, move on and enjoy the space palace?

“这个地方确实美得不可思议……”简脑中不禁如此想道，但随即她又猛然惊醒过来：难道自己已经变成这样的人了吗？一个能轻易对过去耸耸肩就翻篇、然后心安理得地享受这座太空宫殿的人？

She balled her fists and stamped on the gravel. So ridiculously unlucky! A solar flare, what the hell were the chances of something like that?

她攥紧了拳头，狠狠跺了一脚脚下的碎石路。这简直是荒谬的倒霉透顶！太阳耀斑引发事故？谁能料到这种荒唐事竟会发生在自己身上？

But then she realised, it wasn't unlucky. It was almost to be expected. She had been redacted, who knew, maybe a hundred times since leaving prison. Every single Jane iteration chose redaction over cremation. She would keep repeating, again

and again. It would not end until some disaster put her body beyond recovery or human civilisation collapsed. It was practically a certainty that an accident would take place eventually.

然而冷静下来细想，这并非运气不好，而更像是必然会发生的事。自从她离开监狱以来，不知已有多少个版本的简经历过记忆重置——也许是一百次，也许更多。每一位“简”都选择了记忆重置，而不是彻底消亡。她就这样一遍又一遍地重复着生命的循环，直至某次意外灾难彻底摧毁她的身体，或者人类文明本身走向终结。这种意外迟早会发生，只不过是时间问题罢了。

It took time for Jane to decide that life was not a perfect story. Those missing memories, that sentence served, was gone. Besides, she should strive to in some sense be better than her previous selves. Not universally better by all metrics, that was too high an aim. But she should do something they hadn't, otherwise what was the point of her?

她花了很长时间才终于明白：人生从来就不是完美的故事。那些缺失的记忆、已经服完的刑罚，统统都已消逝无踪。更重要的是，她应该努力让自己在某些方面胜过过去的自己。并非事事都比以前完美——那样的目标太过遥远，而是去做些过去的自己从未尝试过的事情，否则她存在的意义又何在呢？

This moment felt like an epiphany. A moment of clarity. She could step out into this world about which she knew so little and she could prosper. That seemed like a good attitude to have at the start of a new life. Maybe she should check the time to record this moment for future ...

在这一瞬间，她仿佛豁然开朗，一切都变得清晰起来。她完全可以迈步走进这个全新的世界，尽管对它的了解还那么有限，但她依旧可以在这里好好生活。这才是开启全新人生最该抱有的心态。也许她现在该记下时间，将这一重要时刻记录下来，留给未来的自己……

This time the sharp transition barely came as a shock, and wasn't unwelcome.

这一次，骤然降临的转变几乎未让她感到任何震惊，甚至还有一种如释重负的轻松。